Contract Manager — User Tutorial

A step-by-step walkthrough of every feature in Contract Manager, written for the people who will actually use it: directors, store managers, and administrators.

> **Screenshots:** image placeholders throughout this document point to `docs/images/<name>.png`. Drop PNGs with those filenames into `docs/images/` to populate them.

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1. Welcome & Who This Is For

Contract Manager is a Windows desktop app for directors and teams to manage vendor contracts end-to-end: tracking costs, budgets, renewals, invoices, competitor offerings, and vendor projects — all in one place.

This tutorial assumes the application is already installed. If you're still setting up the development environment, see the `README.md`.

You'll get the most out of this guide if you are one of:

- A **Super Admin** setting up the app for the first time.
- A **Director** overseeing contracts for one or more departments/branches.
- A **Store Manager** responsible for contracts at a single branch.

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2. Key Concepts (30-second primer)

A handful of ideas show up everywhere in the app. Skim these first — they'll save you time later.

Roles

Role	What they can do
Super Admin	Everything. Configures departments, branches, budgets, users, branding, Gmail, SMTP, the shared database. Sees company-wide data.
Director	Views and edits contracts in their assigned departments and branches. Cannot change settings.
Store Manager	Views and edits contracts at their one assigned branch only.

Scope

Every contract belongs to either a **department** (cross-branch) or a **store branch** (single location). Budgets are set at three levels: **Company**, **Department**, or **Branch**. The Dashboard and most list pages respect the scope selector in the top bar.

Fiscal Year

Spend totals and the monthly spend chart are grouped by the current fiscal year. The fiscal year indicator sits in the top bar next to the scope switcher.

[image]

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3. First Launch: Create Your Admin Account

The very first time anyone opens Contract Manager, the login screen asks you to create the first Super Admin account. This screen only appears once — whoever runs through it becomes the person with full control.

Steps:

1. Launch Contract Manager.
2. On the login screen, you'll see the heading **"Create your admin account"** (instead of "Sign in").
3. Enter your **Full Name**, **Email**, and **Password**.
4. Click **Create Admin Account**.
5. You'll be taken straight to the Dashboard.

[image]

What you just showed off: a zero-friction install — no separate admin console, no license key screen, just one form and you're in.

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4. Signing In

After the first admin exists, the screen behaves like a normal login.

Steps:

1. Launch Contract Manager.
2. Enter your **Email** and **Password**.
3. Click **Sign In**.
4. You land on the Dashboard. If your credentials are wrong, a red banner appears above the button.

[image]

5. Tour of the Interface

The sidebar (left edge)

Item	What it's for
⊞ **Dashboard**	Charts, budget gauges, upcoming renewals, recent activity.
📄 **Contracts**	Browse, search, and create contracts.
📧 **Invoices**	Vendor billing emails pulled from Gmail.
⚖️ **Competitors**	Side-by-side price comparison against competing vendors.
🗂️ **Projects**	Vendor project tracker (Active / On Hold / Completed).
⚙ **Settings**	Branding, org structure, budgets, integrations, users, database.
🖥 **Assets**	IT inventory grid — **Super Admin only**.

Your name and role show at the bottom of the sidebar, along with a **Sign out** button.

The top bar

Two controls that affect almost every screen:

- **Scope switcher** — flip between Company-wide and a specific department/branch.
- **Fiscal year indicator** — the year everything is totaled against.

[image]

6. The Dashboard

The Dashboard is the app's showcase page. Everything here respects the scope chosen in the top bar.

6.1 Budget gauge

A radial gauge at the top-left shows the current scope's utilization:

- **Green** = 0–70 % (Within Budget)
- **Amber** = 70–90 % (Near Limit)
- **Red** = 90 %+ (Over Budget)

It also shows exact **Spent** / **Budget** dollar amounts.

6.2 Summary stat cards

Four at-a-glance numbers:

- **Total Contracts**
- **Active Contracts**
- **Expiring Soon** (anything renewing within 120 days)
- **Annual Spend**

6.3 Monthly spend trend

A chart of spend across the fiscal year. Use the toggle above the chart to flip between **Area**, **Bar**, and **Line** views. Hover any point for a formatted currency tooltip.

6.4 Contract status chart

A breakdown of Active / Expiring Soon / Expired / Pending contracts. Switch between **Donut**, **Bar**, and **Radial** layouts.

6.5 Budget breakdown panel

An expandable panel listing every branch and department with a progress bar, spent vs. budget, remaining dollars, and a status badge. Rows are sorted by utilization, so over-budget units float to the top. Click any row to drill into that unit's detail page.

6.6 Upcoming renewals

Contracts expiring in the next **120 days**, color-coded by urgency (30-day in red, 60-day in amber, 120-day in blue). Click any row to jump to the contract.

6.7 Recent invoices

Latest vendor billing emails imported from Gmail. Anything **> 5 %** over the budgeted amount is flagged red.

6.8 Vendor projects summary

Counts for **Active** / **On Hold** / **Completed** vendor projects, with colored dots.

[image]

What you just showed off: a single-glance operational view — budget health, upcoming risk (renewals), spend trajectory, invoice variance, and project status — all in one screen and all scope-aware.

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7. Setting Up Your Organization (Super Admin)

Before you add contracts, teach the app about your company structure: departments, branches, budgets, and (optionally) your logo.

Everything here lives under **Settings** in the sidebar.

7.1 Add departments

1. Open **Settings** → **Departments**.
2. Type a department name (e.g. *IT*, *Marketing*, *Operations*) in the text box.
3. Click the **Add** button.
4. Repeat for every department.
5. To remove one, click the × next to its name.

7.2 Add store branches

1. Open **Settings** → **Store Branches**.
2. Enter the **Branch #** (a number) and the **Branch name**.
3. Click **Add**.
4. Repeat for every branch.

7.3 Set budgets

Budgets can be set three ways; set as many as you need.

1. Open **Settings** → **Budget Configuration**.
2. Pick a **Scope**: **Company Overall**, **Department**, or **Store Branch**.
3. If scoped to a department or branch, pick the specific one from the dropdown.
4. Pick the **Fiscal Year**.
5. Enter the **Total Budget ($)**.
6. Click **Save Budget**.

The Dashboard's budget gauge immediately reflects the new ceiling.

7.4 Upload your company logo

Dropping in a logo automatically re-skins the app with your brand colors.

1. Open **Settings** → **Branding**.
2. Click **Upload Logo** and select a PNG or JPG.
3. The app extracts the dominant colors from the image and applies them to the sidebar, buttons, and highlights.
4. Optionally tweak the brand color via the color swatch.

[image]

What you just showed off: a bespoke-looking deployment per customer with zero design work — upload a logo, get brand-consistent UI everywhere.

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8. Managing Users & Roles (Super Admin)

Directors and Store Managers are added by a Super Admin from the same Settings page.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Users**.
2. Click **+ Add User**.
3. Fill in **Full Name**, **Email**, **Password**.
4. Pick a **Role**: *Super Admin*, *Director*, or *Store Manager*.
5. Depending on role, you'll see extra fields:
    - **Store Manager** → choose one branch (radio buttons).
    - **Director** → tick multiple branches and multiple departments (checkboxes).
    - **Super Admin** → no assignment; they see everything.
6. Click **Create User**.

To delete a user, click the **×** next to their row (you can't delete yourself).

[image]

What you just showed off: granular role-based access — a Store Manager only ever sees their branch, a Director only sees their assigned scope, and auditors can't accidentally see data that isn't theirs.

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9. Adding Your First Contract

Head to **Contracts** in the sidebar. You'll see three tabs along the top: **Contracts**, **Search**, and **Contract Creation**.

To add a contract manually, Super Admins can click **+ New Contract** in the top-right of the page.

Steps:

1. Click **+ New Contract**.
2. Fill in the form:
    - **Vendor Name** (required).
    - **Contract Scope**: *Department* or *Store Branch*.
    - **Department** *(if department scope)* or **Branch** *(if branch scope)*.
    - **Cost Allocation** — for department contracts, you'll be asked whether to split the cost across branches/departments. Pick **No** to charge the whole thing to the owning department, or **Yes** to open the allocation editor and enter per-unit amounts.
    - **Start Date** and **End Date** (required).
    - **Monthly Cost** and **Annual Cost** (annual auto-fills from monthly).
    - **Total Contract Value**.
    - **POC Name** / **Email** / **Phone** — the vendor contact for this agreement.
3. Click 📎 **Upload Contract File** to attach the signed PDF.
4. Click **Save**.

The new contract appears in the Contracts list immediately.

[image]

What you just showed off: contracts that live at the right organizational level (dept vs branch) with optional fine-grained cost splits — useful when IT signs one contract that bills back to multiple stores.

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10. Working With an Existing Contract

Click any row in the Contracts list to open its detail page. The header shows the vendor, dates, POC, and status. Below that sits a tab bar.

Tab	What it does
Overview	Core contract info — status, financials, POC, dates.
Line Items	Editable table of individual items. Add a row, set description/quantity/unit price, and the total price is calculated for you.
Renewals	Historical record of previous renewals — date, previous cost, new cost, license-count change, reason. Click **+ Add Renewal** to record one.
Notes	Free-form vendor notes, stamped with the author and date. Click **+ Add Note**.
Projects	Vendor projects linked to this contract (active engagements, migrations, POCs).
Competitors	Competing offerings and their prices. Used by the Competitors page to show savings.
Allocations *(department contracts only)*	Per-branch cost split. Click **Edit Allocations** to open the editor, or **Calculate from Assets** to auto-split by asset counts (see §16).

[image]

What you just showed off: every artifact about a vendor — pricing history, notes, projects, competing offers, cost splits — lives in one place next to the contract itself, not scattered across spreadsheets.

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11. Searching & Filtering Contracts

The **Search** tab on the Contracts page is a full filter panel.

Filters available (sticky left sidebar):

- **Vendor Name**
- **Point of Contact**
- **Status** — multi-select: Active, Expiring Soon, Expired, Pending.
- **Cost** — choose the field (*Annual / Monthly / Total Value*) and operator (*Over / Under / Between / Any amount*).
- **Start Date** — From/To range.

- **End Date** — From/To range.
- **Department**
- **Branch**
- **Renews Within** — number of days.

Any active filter shows a "filtered" indicator at the top. Click **Clear all** to reset.

To save the current view out as a file, click **Export** in the page header (exports to CSV/Excel).

[image]

What you just showed off: instant answers to questions like *"Which contracts over $50 k/year are up for renewal in the next 60 days in the Operations department?"* — without touching a spreadsheet.

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12. Bulk Importing Contracts

If you already track contracts in a spreadsheet, you don't need to re-enter them one by one.

Steps:

1. On the Contracts page header, click ↑ **Import Contracts**.
2. Pick your CSV or Excel (`.xlsx`) file.
3. Map each column in the file to a contract field (Vendor, Start Date, Annual Cost, etc.).
4. Pick which **department** or **branch** each row belongs to (or map that from a column).
5. Review the preview.
6. Click **Import** to commit.

Rows with errors are flagged; valid rows are added in one shot.

[image]

What you just showed off: a clean on-ramp from whatever tracking you used before (a vendor spreadsheet, an export from another tool) into a structured database — no manual re-keying.

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13. Tracking Renewals

Contract Manager watches every contract's end date and reminds you before each one lapses.

How the schedule works

- Reminders fire at **120, 90, 60, and 30 days** before the end date.
- The scheduler runs once at app startup and then **daily at 9 AM**.
- Each contract/day combination fires only once — you won't get repeated notifications on the same milestone.

Where reminders show up

- **Windows desktop notifications** from the scheduler. Reminders ≤30 days out are marked *critical*.
- **Dashboard** → **Upcoming Renewals** lists everything renewing in the next 120 days.
- **Email notifications** to relevant users, when SMTP is configured (see §18).

[image]

What you just showed off: nothing lapses by accident — even if nobody opens the app, the scheduler runs in the background and fires a desktop toast.

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14. Comparing Competitors

The **Competitors** page shows every active contract with at least one competing offering, and tells you which deal is currently best.

To add competitor data:

1. Open the contract's detail page (§10).
2. Switch to the **Competitors** tab.
3. Click **+ Add Competitor Offering**.
4. Enter: **Competitor Vendor**, **Offering Name**, **Price**, and optional **Notes**.
5. Save.

To see the savings summary:

1. Click **Competitors** in the sidebar.
2. Each contract is listed with its current annual cost.
3. Cards show a **"Save $X/yr"** badge if a competitor is cheaper, or a **"Best deal"** badge if the current vendor wins.
4. Click any card to expand a side-by-side comparison table.

[image]

What you just showed off: a built-in negotiation worksheet — when it's time to renegotiate, you already have competing quotes on file and the dollar savings calculated.

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15. Vendor Projects Tracker

For ongoing vendor engagements beyond the core contract (a migration, a pilot, a support project), use the **Projects** page.

Steps:

1. Click **Projects** in the sidebar.
2. The top of the page shows three clickable stat cards — **Active**, **On Hold**, **Completed**. Click one to filter.
3. Click **+ Add Project**.
4. Pick the **Vendor/Contract**, enter a **Name**, **Status**, **Start/End Dates**, and **Description**.
5. Save.
6. To change status later, use the dropdown on the project card.

You can also add projects from a contract's **Projects** tab — they'll show up on this page automatically.

[image]

What you just showed off: contracts and the work delivered under them stay connected — a renewal conversation can pull up *"these are the 4 projects we ran with this vendor last year"* in seconds.

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16. IT Assets Inventory (Super Admin)

The **Assets** page (sidebar, visible only to Super Admins) is a grid that tracks how many computers, thin clients, servers, printers, and Ingenico terminals live at each branch.

Why it matters: department-level contracts (e.g. a single software license covering the whole company) can be auto-split across branches in proportion to asset counts. That means the branch with 120 machines pays more than the one with 12, without any manual math.

Steps:

1. Click **Assets** in the sidebar.
2. The grid shows one row per branch and one column per asset type.

3. Type a number into any cell.
4. Click **Save** at the top.

To import from a spreadsheet:

1. Click **Import**.
2. Pick your file.
3. Review the preview (any branch in the file that doesn't match an existing branch is flagged).
4. Click **Apply Import**.

To use asset counts for a contract's allocation:

1. Open the contract's detail page.
2. Go to the **Allocations** tab.
3. Click **Calculate from Assets**.
4. Review the auto-computed split, then **Save**.

[image]

What you just showed off: cost allocation that reflects reality — branches pay in proportion to what they actually use.

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17. Gmail Integration

Contract Manager can pull vendor billing emails out of Gmail and turn them into Invoice records automatically.

17.1 Connecting Gmail (one-time, Super Admin)

1. Open **Settings** → **Gmail Integration**.
2. Click **Connect Gmail Account**.
3. Your browser opens the Google OAuth consent screen. Sign in and authorize.
4. Google shows you an authorization code.
5. Copy the code and paste it into the modal in the app.
6. Click **Connect**.

The section now shows the connected email address and a **Disconnect Gmail** button.

> Before this step will work, the `GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID` and `GOOGLE_CLIENT_SECRET` environment variables must be set. See the `README.md`'s Gmail section for details.

17.2 Syncing invoices

1. Click **Invoices** in the sidebar.
2. Click 🔄 **Sync Gmail** (top-right).
3. The app scans Gmail for billing emails, extracts amounts, matches vendors to contracts, and creates Invoice rows.

17.3 Reading the Invoices page

- Each card shows the email subject, sender, received date, vendor, **Amount**, and the **Budgeted** amount if the contract has one.
- A **variance badge** shows whether the invoice is over (red) or under (green) budget.
- A banner at the top of the page warns about invoices **>5 %** over their budgeted amount.
- Editors and above can remove rows.

[image]

What you just showed off: an automated spend audit — the app pulls bills, reconciles them against the contracted amount, and surfaces overages without anyone opening a bank statement.

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18. Email Notifications (SMTP)

Keep the team in the loop when contracts or budgets change.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Email Notifications**.
2. Turn on **Enable email notifications**.
3. Fill in:
    - **SMTP Host** (e.g. `smtp.gmail.com`)
    - **SMTP Port** (usually `587`)
    - **Username** / **Email**
    - **Password**
    - **From Address**
    - **Use SSL/TLS** checkbox (tick for port 465)
4. Click **Save Settings**.
5. Click **Send Test Email** to confirm the connection.

Who gets notified

The app targets recipients by role and scope:

- **Super Admins** — all notifications.
- **Directors** — notifications that touch one of their assigned departments or branches.
- **Store Managers** — notifications that touch their branch.

Events that trigger an email:

- Contract created / updated / deleted.
- Budget updated.

[image]

What you just showed off: the right people hear about the right changes — no "hey, did you know the Acme contract got renewed?" on Monday morning.

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19. E-Signature via Documenso

If your organization uses Documenso for digital signatures, wire it up once and you can send contracts out for signature from inside the app.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **E-Signature**.
2. Enter the **Documenso API URL** (for the hosted service, `https://app.documenso.com`).
3. Enter your **API Key**. Use the show/hide toggle if you want to double-check it.
4. Click **Save**.
5. Click **Test Connection** to confirm the credentials work.

[image]

What you just showed off: signatures live next to the contract record instead of in a separate inbox thread.

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20. Sharing the Database Across Your Team

Contract Manager stores its data in a single SQLite file. Point every teammate's installation at the same file on a shared network drive, and you've got a shared database.

Steps (on every teammate's machine):

1. Place the database file on a network drive everyone can reach.
2. Open **Settings** → **Shared Database Location**.
3. Click **Select Network Folder** and pick the folder holding `contract-manager.db`.
4. The app restarts its connection against the shared file.

> **Note:** SQLite uses WAL mode for better concurrent reads. Avoid heavy writes from multiple users at the same moment — stagger bulk imports.

[image]

What you just showed off: a 6-person team sharing a single source of truth without standing up a database server.

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21. Department & Branch Drill-down

From the Dashboard's **Budget Breakdown** panel, click any row and you land on that unit's own detail page (`/department/:id` or `/branch/:id`). It's a focused, scoped version of the main dashboard:

- Back button to the Dashboard.
- Entity name with a **Department** or **Branch** badge.
- Budget status indicator (Within / Near / Over).
- Budget gauge, just for this unit.
- Stat cards: Total Contracts, Active, Annual Spend, Budget Remaining.
- Monthly spend trend, scoped.
- Upcoming renewals, scoped.

[image]

What you just showed off: a Director can drill from company-wide to their own area in one click and see everything in context.

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22. Signing Out

At the bottom of the sidebar, under your name and role, click **Sign out**. You're returned to the login screen immediately. No background session remains.

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23. Troubleshooting & FAQ

"I don't see the Assets page in the sidebar." Assets is Super Admin only. Ask a Super Admin to upgrade your role, or have them manage assets for you.

"Gmail sync imported 0 invoices." Make sure the Gmail account was connected recently (§17.1), that billing emails exist in the mailbox, and that the sender address vaguely matches a known vendor. If a message doesn't match a vendor name in your contracts, it won't be imported.

"I'm not getting renewal toast notifications." The scheduler runs once at startup and again daily at 9 AM. If you launched the app after 9 AM, today's 9 AM check is skipped until the next day — but the startup check still runs. Confirm the contract's end date is exactly 120, 90, 60, or 30 days away (the window for each milestone is ±1 day).

"My edits aren't visible to my teammates." Each teammate needs to point the app at the shared database (§20). If one person's copy is still using the local default, they have their own private data.

"I uploaded a logo but the colors didn't change." Try a higher-resolution image. Color extraction samples the dominant colors from the PNG/JPG you provide; very small icons produce low-confidence palettes.

"Test email fails but credentials look right." If you're using Gmail for SMTP, you'll need an **App Password**, not your regular Google account password. Generate one in your Google account's security settings.

Questions, corrections, or a feature not covered here? Open an issue in the repository — the tutorial gets updated alongside the app.